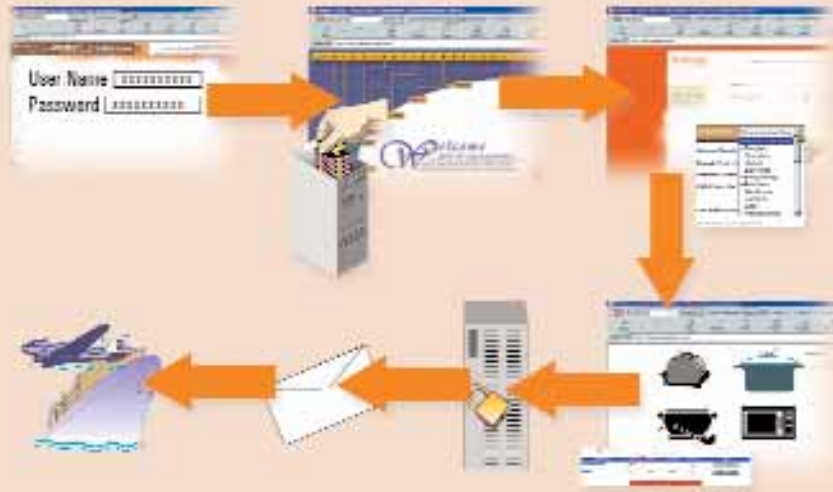


Better Shopping Guide

- Does the portal provide contact details (phone number/e-mail)?
- Does it specify any person's name whom you can contact if you need assistance?
- Does it have an FAQ section?
- Is the help desk responsive?
- Is it a secure site (check for 'https://' in the URL)?
- Is it registered with Verisign, CCNOW, www.truste.org, or other international bodies for security/redressal?
- What does the fine print say about how the product is shipped? Are there any hidden costs, mode of payment, etc?

Infographic: Jaya Shetty

The Shopping Route



- For any normal e-commerce transaction, you are required to register with the site wherein you provide your personal details. A small text file called a cookie is placed on your computer. This file usually keeps track of the user preferences, which helps the site to keep a record of regular visitors/users. For this you must have the 'cookie' options enabled on your browser.
- The page where you enter your details is mostly in a normal HTML format, but may also use high-end languages such as Java and C to process your information online. The basic drop-down menus and radio boxes are a part of the online form and are designed to aid you while surfing through the various sections.
- When you shop for a particular product and intend to purchase it, you are required to add that item to your portfolio list, i.e 'add to cart'. This specially designed 'shopping cart'

software allows you to keep track of your shopping as you browse through the site.

It even helps you keep a running total of your expenses. Therefore, the software designed has to be simple and elegant so as to entice the user to shop for the product without any major hassles.

- When the order is placed, it usually goes through a secure server transaction. It is likely that when you place an online order you will receive a confirmation through e-mail telling you the order number. Remember your order number or better still, to be on the safe side, print (photocopy) the order confirmation document.

This can definitely help you to follow up on your purchase with the concerned site. Finally, the site ships your order to the right destination.

marmalades to frozen food products, and have these delivered to your doorstep (although they are currently shipping only in Bangalore, Hyderabad and Chennai).

The site features a reward program called 'Fab points' which you earn as you shop. You can also try your hand at the contest and quizzes section. If watches are what make you tick, then choose from a list of national and international brands. Or run through the movies and music sections for some good discounts. This site also provides for secure transactions via SSL encryption.

In the midst of this, can www.indiatimes.com be far behind? At <http://shopping.indiatimes.com> you will find a one-stop mega portal for practically everything under the sun. Though the site has a wide range of products in certain categories, in others

there are just a bare minimum selection of products.

However, the site takes care of this shortcoming by providing links to other shopping channels that partner the site. Aside from the regular goodies, this portal provides you with collector items such as T-shirts, mugs and souvenirs.

The site also has hot deals and pick of the week sections. What's more, you can personalise your gifts by having your photograph embossed on them, but there isn't much variety in the options for the accompanying message. This portal does have its fine points but needs some work if it has to stand out from the rest.

You could also drop in at www.sifymall.com, a portal that's loaded with some really big names offering a wide product range and a good vari-